

Chalk Hearts on the Prairie

Cowboy story • 3-4 years old



Tommy the cowboy rode his gentle horse, Dusty, across the wide, warm plains. The sun was gold. The grass was soft. Tommy smiled. "Hello, sky," he said. "Hello, wind." Dusty tossed his mane. They walked and walked.

Tommy had a small box in his saddle. Inside were sticks of bright chalk. He loved chalk. He loved to leave little marks on the round rocks by the trail. He wanted to share happiness. He wanted to say, "We were here." He wanted others to know that this place cares.

One morning, Tommy met a family of travelers by a big, friendly rock. A mother, a father, and a little girl named Mei stood with their wagon. Mei liked Tommy's chalk. She watched him draw a blue flower. She watched him draw a yellow sun. "Can I try?" she asked. Tommy nodded. "Yes," he said. "Come draw with me." Mei drew a red heart. They laughed. Dusty nickered.

Tommy and Mei left marks together. They left a green leaf. They left a purple star. They left a tiny horse. The marks were bright on the round rocks. The marks were small and kind. People who passed would smile. People would feel seen.

Farther on, Tommy met an old rancher named Joe. Joe had a tired hat and kind eyes. Joe did not speak the same words as Tommy and Mei. He spoke a different language. Tommy slowed his horse. He smiled. Joe smiled back. Tommy pointed to the chalk marks. Joe pointed to the sky. They both laughed. Tommy drew a line. Joe drew a circle. The circle and the line looked like a sun and a road. They shared the chalk. They shared a cup of warm tea. They were friends.

Later, a herd of sheep wandered across the path. Tommy and the travelers helped guide the sheep with gentle hands. They spoke soft words. They sang a little tune. The sheep followed the song. Dusty stood still. The people worked together. They did not rush. They did not shout. They were calm and kind. The sheep found their way.

When the day turned orange, Tommy and his new friends reached a wide, warm canyon. The rocks were tall and smooth. Tommy took a stick of blue chalk. He drew a small map on a flat stone. He drew homes, trails, and a big heart. He

said, "This mark is for everyone." Mei added two stars. Joe traced a circle around the heart. Dusty stamped his hoof as if to say, "Good."

Night came with soft stars. Tommy, Mei, Joe, and the travelers sat together. They told small stories. They shared warm bread. The chalk marks glowed in their memory like tiny lights. Tommy felt brave and kind. He felt strong and gentle.

Before they left, Tommy put one last mark on the flat stone. He drew a hand and a promise. The promise said, "Be kind. Be brave." Then he drew a tiny sun. The sun smiled.

Tommy rode away with Dusty. He left a trail of bright marks. He left friends who smiled. He left a world a little kinder than before. The wind said, "Goodbye, friend." Tommy waved. He kept his chalk close. He knew he would come back to draw more hearts.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) Who is the cowboy in the story?

- Tommy the cowboy
- Dusty the horse
- Mei the girl
- Joe the rancher

2) What did Tommy carry in his saddle?

- Bright chalk
- A big hat
- A metal map
- A red ball

3) What did Tommy and friends draw on the rocks?

- Hearts and stars
- Cars and trains
- Pizzas and cakes
- Shoes and socks

4) How did they help the sheep?

- They were gentle and calm
- They shouted loudly
- They ran away
- They fell asleep

Correct answers:

1) Tommy the cowboy 2) Bright chalk 3) Hearts and stars 4) They were gentle and calm

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Gentle horse: A calm, soft horse that moves slowly and is kind.

Plains: Wide, flat land with grass where animals can walk and run.

Saddle: A seat put on a horse so a person can sit and ride.

Chalk: A soft stick used for drawing bright marks on rocks or ground.

Round rocks: Stones that are smooth and curved, not sharp or flat.

Travelers: People who are moving from one place to another, often by wagon.

Wagon: A big cart with wheels used to carry people or things.

Nickered: The soft sound a horse makes when it is happy or friendly.

Rancher: A person who cares for animals and works on a big farm.

A different language: Words people use that are not the same as yours.

Herd: A group of animals that stay together and move as one.

Sheep: Soft, woolly animals that live in flocks and say 'baa'.

Calm: Quiet and not scared or noisy; feeling peaceful inside.

Canyon: A deep, wide space between tall rocks with walls on both sides.

Hoof: The hard foot of an animal like a horse or sheep.

Promise: A words you say to keep something true or to help someone.